OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Questions to Shoalhaven Council on the 2026-27 budget adoption

Sent 29 June 2026 · To Mayor White, Cr Proudfoot, Cr Tribe, Cr Norris, Cr Boyd, Cr Krikstolaitis, Cr Killian, Cr Dunn, Cr Casmiri, Cr Clancy, Cr Wilkins, Council Email · Response requested by 20 July 2026

Eye on Shoalhaven Council
steveprothero.substack.com
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OPEN LETTER

Mayor Patricia White

Councillors of Shoalhaven City Council
Re: The adoption of the 2026–27 DPOP — what was not asked, what was not acknowledged, and what was claimed

I write in the knowledge that correspondence from this publication has, in recent months, been declined on the basis of guidance relating to unreasonable conduct. I note, for the record, that the application of that guidance to a public interest publication with more than 3,800 local readers is itself a matter currently before the NSW Ombudsman. The questions in this letter are not personal complaints. They are questions of public administration, put openly, on behalf of a readership that represents approximately 5.1 per cent of Shoalhaven's registered voters. They are questions any member of the public could put at an ordinary council meeting. I put them here, in writing, on the public record — and will publish whatever response is received, including none.

The meeting at which council adopted its 2026–27 Delivery Program, Operational Plan and Budget was, by the transcript, a short one. A $520 million document was adopted unanimously after questions that focused almost entirely on fee line items. That is a matter of public record.

So are the following.

Question 1: Why did no councillor ask for the revised deficit figure?

The adoption meeting confirmed, in direct terms, that the software licensing costs in the adopted budget are "significantly higher than the one million uplift" included in the draft that went on public exhibition. Cr Jemma Tribe acknowledged the overall worsening in passing before moving on to ask about capital works line items.

- **No councillor asked what the revised General Fund deficit now is.**
- **No councillor asked what the software blowout means for the Operating Performance Ratio, already projected at negative 2.6 per cent against an OLG**

benchmark requiring it to be above zero.

The community spent 28 days commenting on a document that was out of date by the time it was adopted. Could any councillor confirm what the revised deficit figure in the adopted budget is?

Question 2: Why were staff thanked without acknowledgment of the errors?

The adoption meeting opened with Director Buchman disclosing that the exhibited document was "silent" on fees for the Ulladulla Civic Centre — a whole facility's fee schedule missing from a 400-page document on public exhibition for 28 days.

A second error was confirmed in response to a question from Cr Tribe: an administrative mistake had incorrectly deleted an existing spectator fee, contributing to the public confusion that arose during the exhibition period.

Despite this, Cr Bob Proudfoot closed the debate by congratulating staff without qualification. Cr Tribe reiterated those thanks. Neither speaker acknowledged the errors.

Would any councillor explain what quality assurance processes apply to DPOP documents before they go to public exhibition, and whether those processes will be reviewed in light of the errors confirmed at this meeting?

Question 3: What is the basis for describing the budget as "completely transparent"?

At the adoption meeting, Cr Proudfoot described the budget as "right to the last dollar" transparent and "completely transparent." He praised the quality of the council's formal responses to the 36 public submissions as "outstanding."

The 36 submissions include at least one that asked specifically for: a timeline for completing the three "TBA" infrastructure benchmarks; a consolidated residential cost trajectory across three years; an indicative range for the Special Rate Variation flagged in the document; a fuel cost sensitivity analysis; and a disaggregated view of structural versus one-off improvement drivers.

Cr Proudfoot's evidence for "complete transparency" was a standard financial risk caveat in the document.

The three infrastructure benchmarks remain "TBA." No consolidated household cost figure was published. The SRV was flagged but not sized. No fuel sensitivity analysis was provided. The software cost remained unquantified at the time of adoption.

Could Cr Proudfoot, or any councillor, explain which of those submissions received substantive written responses, and on what basis the quality of those responses was characterised as outstanding?

The broader pattern this raises

The council majority campaigned in 2024 on financial management, fiscal responsibility, and trust. Since then, Mayor White has described the deficit as heading toward "next to nil" — a claim made when the council's own projections showed an $18.5 million deficit.

Three of four OLG performance ratios remain below benchmark. The General Fund Operating Performance Ratio is projected to remain negative in the adopted 2026–27 budget.

Against that record, residents are entitled to ask whether the positive framing applied to this budget — "phenomenal turnaround," "complete transparency," "outstanding" responses — reflects the financial documents accurately, or whether it reflects a political interest in sustaining a narrative of successful management ahead of an election cycle.

The questions above are designed to help the community make that assessment on the basis of evidence, not assertion.

I put these questions on the public record and will report whatever is received in response, including silence.

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Note to councillors receiving a copy of this letter
The questions above are put on the public record. If you believe they warrant answers, you are in a position to raise them directly in the chamber — through a Question on Notice, a Notice of Motion, or a question to the Mayor in open council. That is one of the most effective ways to place these matters before the community in a forum where a response cannot be declined. In particular: asking for the revised deficit figure in the adopted budget, and asking what quality assurance process applies to DPOP documents before they go to exhibition, are questions that could be raised at the next ordinary meeting. This publication will report whatever is raised and whatever is answered.
